



Sony Xperia M

Sony unveiled the Xperia M – a new 4-inch Android smartphone with a dual-core processor and 5 megapixel camera



Skype for Windows 8

Skype for Windows 8 update brings a better video messaging and HD video support. <http://dgit.in/15yN4mO>

Smartphones Test

4.2-inch display has a resolution of 1280x768 pixels – greater than the iPhone 5's. In the density stakes too, the Z10's 355ppi is better than 326ppi on the iPhone 5. In our comparisons, the text handling on the Z10's display is better than the iPhone 5. The Q10 also renders text very well, despite the smaller size. As far as data plans are concerned, BB10 phones don't need a dedicated data plan to work, and any generic 2G/3G plan works perfectly. If you are into side-loading Android apps on to the BB10 devices, then you get a huge variety of additional apps. If you aren't, BB10 still has some way to go before it can come close to Android and iOS.

Sony Xperia Z & HTC Butterfly:

The early 1080p phones

Straightaway, there was a bit of chaos as the Xperia Z beat the HTC Butterfly in the very first benchmark test that we ran. While the Butterfly scored 7,744 in the Quadrant test, the Xperia Z scored 7,863. If that is not a verification of the power package and the blazing fast performance, nothing will ever be, considering this is Sony's first quad-core phone. The HTC clawed its own back in the AnTuTu test, where it scored 20,905, while the Xperia Z clocked 18,426. But, these tests do clearly indicate that the performance of the Xperia Z is not to be taken lightly, even though both phones tend to get overshadowed by the Samsung Galaxy S4 and the HTC One.

The Butterfly's display was the first 1080p one to be launched in India, and pretty much showed the way forward. The SLCD3 is a huge improvement over the SLCD2, and brings colour richness closer to the AMOLED series of displays,

while remaining more natural. The 5-inch display on the Xperia Z is what Sony calls the "Reality Display", and boasts of 443ppi. The HTC Butterfly's SLCD-3 display has the same resolution, but falls slightly short at 441ppi. But, the Butterfly's display has an advantage in terms of text crispness, and readability of the written word. Between the two, the Xperia Z has a better camera, but the HTC Butterfly has a better build and display.

Samsung Galaxy S4 & HTC One:

Race to the finish line

In the benchmarks tests, the Samsung Galaxy S4's octa-core processor has the lead in the scores. However, in the real world usage scenario, it is too close to call between the two. The app opening times, the smoothness of the UI and both phones handle the exact same application load with the same dash of smoothness. Since we are dealing with quad-core and octa-core SoCs here, let us make one thing very clear – you will hardly see any real performance boost on the octa-core over the quad core in a typical smartphone usage scenario as you go about doing your work daily.

Samsung carries on with the AMOLED family of displays, and that also includes keeping faith with the PenTile display type that the SIII got a lot of flak for. This display type does have a battery consumption advantage over the SLCD3. But the HTC One's display has a significant advantage when you compare the purity of the whites, even-ness of colours and text rendering. The on-screen keyboard on the Galaxy S4 is disappointing, because despite so much space available, the keys are small and there is too much spacing between them.

Samsung's TouchWiz has been tweaked over time, while HTC's BlinkFeed UI is something that has been recently introduced. Blinkfeed does have a huge advantage in terms of simplicity and how it packs in info in one screen, leaving two more for you to put any widgets on. Too many screens can actually be confusing after a while. The camera performance, across all lighting conditions, also goes in favour of the HTC One, which also has the advantage of the Zoe features to boast about.

The Galaxy S4 is loaded with a whole host of features – multi-window, quick glance, smart stay etc., which no other phone can match up to. But, features can only take you so far.

Apple iPhone 5: The "Mr Consistent" of the smartphone world

If ever there was a phone that consistently set the benchmark in multiple facets for the smartphone world, it has been the iPhone. Certain Android phones have now started to match the pristine build quality that various versions of the iPhone have brought along – the emphasis on glass and aluminium build elements. It is only now that the Retina Display is being surpassed by the 1080p displays on various Android phones, but some Windows Phones are well behind even now. The iOS has always brought out differing opinions – some say simplicity is brilliant, yet others say it is too bland in the face of Android's geekiness. But, since Apple has complete control over the hardware and the software, the iPhone 5 remains a perfect fusion of both. No Android or WP device can even dream of emulating that. In the age of huge display phones, the 4-inch

display on the iPhone 5 does appeal to the demographic who want the comfort factor while not sacrificing on functionality. The arrival of iOS 7 is going to enhance the device even more.

THE WINNERS

After all the discussions and tests, here are our handpicked winners among all the high-end smartphones.

Best Performer: HTC One

It may not have an 8-core processor, but the quad-core powerhouse does a brilliant job. The HTC One has by far the most premium build quality across all Android smartphones. Has a significantly better display than the Galaxy S4, a better on-screen keyboard, camera and lesser numbers of features that don't become too overwhelming.

Best Value: LG Nexus 4

This phone, with vanilla Android experience, is undoubtedly the device that all Android users can consider. Affordable, very good performance, built well and the promise of instant Android updates – what more could one expect from a smartphone that has the direct blessing of Google, and costs much lesser than ₹30,000?

Editor's Pick: Apple iPhone 5

This is a phone that still has the aspirational value like no other device out there. Exquisite build quality, perfect marriage between hardware and software, good display and very comfortable on-screen keyboard, still a very competent camera and the upcoming iOS 7 make this the phone to buy, for anyone who believes Android isn't their cup of tea.